

UNOFFICIAL FAN GUIDE

2026 SEASON GUIDE

The Tracks of Formula 1

A Beginner's Guide to the Formula 1 Season

Circuit Guide

Formula 1 races at some of the most famous circuits in the world. Each track has its own character, challenges, and history. This guide covers the most notable circuits on the 2026 calendar to help new fans understand what makes each venue special.

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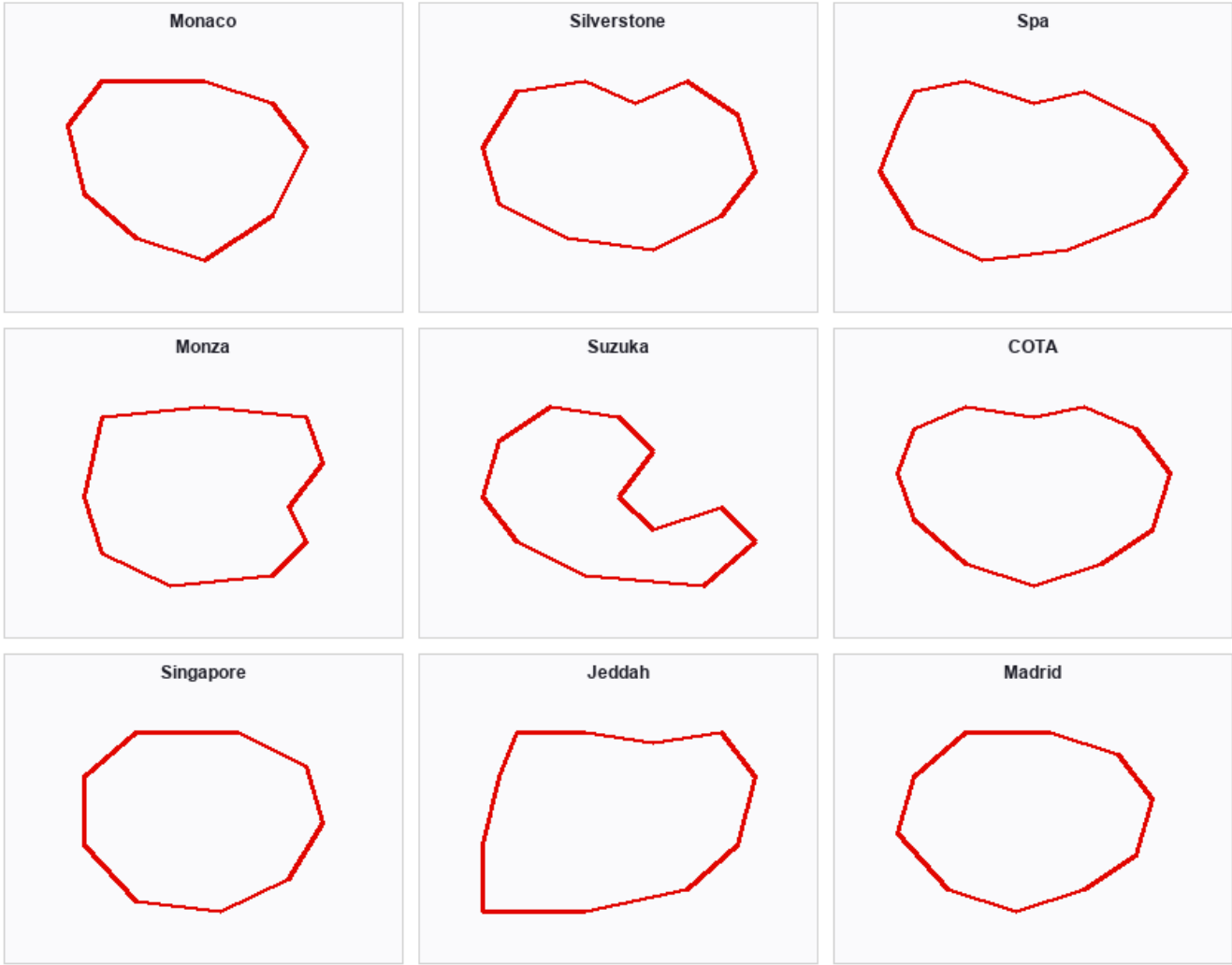
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Featured Circuit Outlines



Simplified outlines of the 9 featured circuits

Circuit de Monaco

Monte Carlo, Monaco | 3.337 km (shortest on calendar) | 19 turns | Lap record: 1:12.909 (Lewis Hamilton, 2021)

Street Circuit

The crown jewel of F1. This tight street circuit winds through the streets of Monte Carlo, past the famous Casino and along the harbor. Overtaking is nearly impossible, making qualifying and strategy crucial. It's the most prestigious race on the calendar and has been held since 1929.

Famous sections: Casino Square (sharp hairpin after uphill climb), the Tunnel (unique light-to-dark transition at high speed), the Swimming Pool chicane (ultra-tight at the harbor), Rascasse (penultimate corner, slow hairpin)

Overtaking: Extremely limited. The Nouvelle Chicane after the tunnel is the only realistic overtaking spot. Active aero zones will be minimal. Track position is everything at Monaco.

Silverstone Circuit

Silverstone, United Kingdom | 5.891 km | 18 turns | Lap record: 1:27.097 (Max Verstappen, 2020)

Permanent Circuit

The home of British motorsport and where the first-ever Formula 1 World Championship race was held in 1950. Silverstone is one of the fastest circuits on the calendar, known for its high-speed corners that test aerodynamic performance. The passionate British crowd creates an electric atmosphere.

Famous sections: Maggotts-Becketts-Chapel (legendary high-speed S-curves that are the ultimate test of car balance and driver courage), Copse (fast right-hander), Stowe (high-speed braking zone)

Overtaking: Good opportunities at the end of the Wellington Straight into Brooklands and at the end of the Hangar Straight into Stowe. Active aero will be especially effective on the long straights.

Spa-Francorchamps

Stavelot, Belgium | 7.004 km (longest on calendar) | 19 turns | Lap record: 1:44.701 (Sergio Perez, 2024)

Permanent Circuit

The longest and one of the most dramatic circuits in F1. Set in the Ardennes forest, Spa features dramatic elevation changes and is famous for unpredictable weather - it can rain on one part of the circuit while the sun shines on another. A true driver's circuit that rewards bravery and skill.

Famous sections: Eau Rouge / Raidillon (iconic uphill left-right-left sequence taken at over 300 km/h, one of the most famous corners in motorsport), La Source (tight hairpin at the start), Blanchimont (flat-out left kink at extreme speed), Bus Stop chicane

Overtaking: Excellent opportunities. The long Kemmel Straight after Eau Rouge is one of the best overtaking spots in F1. Additional chances into La Source and at the Bus Stop chicane.

Autodromo Nazionale Monza

Monza, Italy | 5.793 km | 11 turns | Lap record: 1:20.901 (Lando Norris, 2025)

Permanent Circuit

The 'Temple of Speed' - the fastest circuit on the calendar with average speeds exceeding 260 km/h. Home of the Italian Grand Prix since 1950, Monza is Ferrari's home race and the Tifosi (Ferrari fans) create an unforgettable atmosphere. Low-downforce setups and top speed are critical here.

Famous sections: Curva Grande (long, sweeping right-hander), the two Lesmo corners (medium-speed right-handers through parkland), Variante Ascari (fast chicane), Parabolica/Curva Alboreto (long right-hander leading onto the main straight)

Overtaking: Plentiful. The three chicanes (Variante del Rettifilo, Variante della Roggia, Variante Ascari) all offer heavy braking zones. Slipstreaming on the long straights is a key tactic.

Suzuka Circuit

Suzuka, Japan | 5.807 km | 18 turns | Lap record: 1:30.983 (Lewis Hamilton, 2019)

Permanent Circuit

One of the most technically demanding circuits in F1 and the only figure-of-eight layout on the calendar (the track crosses over itself via an overpass). Suzuka is revered by drivers for its flowing, high-speed nature. The Japanese fans are known for their deep knowledge and respect for the sport.

Famous sections: The Esses (S-curves from turns 3-7, a breathtaking high-speed sequence), Degner curves (fast right-handers), Spoon curve (double-apex left-hander), 130R (once flat-out, still one of the fastest corners in F1), the Casio Triangle chicane

Overtaking: Moderate. Main opportunities at the end of the back straight into the Casio Triangle and at Turn 1. The flowing nature of the circuit makes following difficult through the Esses.

Circuit of the Americas (COTA)

Austin, Texas, USA | 5.513 km | 20 turns | Lap record: 1:36.169 (Charles Leclerc, 2019)

Permanent Circuit

Purpose-built for F1 and opened in 2012, COTA combines design elements from great circuits worldwide. The dramatic uphill run to Turn 1 is one of F1's most exciting starts. Located in Austin, Texas, it has become a cornerstone of F1's growing American fanbase.

Famous sections: Turn 1 (steep uphill blind apex, crucial for race starts), the Esses at turns 3-6 (inspired by Silverstone's Maggotts-Becketts), Turn 11 (hairpin, key overtaking point), the stadium section (turns 16-18, amphitheater with massive spectator capacity)

Overtaking: Good opportunities at Turn 1 (especially on lap 1), Turn 12 (end of back straight), and Turn 15. Active aero will enhance overtaking on the long DRS/straight zones.

Jeddah Corniche Circuit

Jeddah, Saudi Arabia | 6.174 km | 27 turns | Lap record: 1:30.734 (Lewis Hamilton, 2021)

Street Circuit

The fastest street circuit in F1 history, averaging over 250 km/h. Jeddah's layout runs along the Red Sea waterfront with walls on both sides at extreme speed. It's a high-risk, high-reward circuit with limited visibility through several blind corners. The combination of street circuit barriers and high speed makes it uniquely challenging.

Famous sections: Turn 1 (fast entry into the circuit), the sweeping section from turns 4-12 (high-speed flowing sequence near the coast), Turn 22 (fast kink near the walls), the final sector (tight and technical approaching the main straight)

Overtaking: Reasonable opportunities on the main straight and at the end of sector 2's long blast. The tight final sector can bunch cars up, creating chances into Turn 1.

Marina Bay Street Circuit

Singapore | 4.940 km | 19 turns | Lap record: 1:35.867 (Lewis Hamilton, 2023)

Street Circuit

F1's original night race, held under floodlights in the heart of Singapore's financial district. The Marina Bay circuit is one of the most physically demanding races of the year - the combination of heat, humidity, bumpy surfaces, and nearly 2 hours of racing makes it an endurance test. The spectacular nighttime setting with the city skyline as a backdrop makes it a visual highlight.

Famous sections: Turn 5 (tight left-hander by the Esplanade), the Anderson Bridge section (turns 7-8, around the historic bridge), Turn 14 (tight corner under the Singapore Flyer), Turn 16-17 (tight sequence by Marina Bay Sands)

Overtaking: Limited but possible. The main straight into Turn 1 is the best chance. The Raffles Boulevard section and Turn 7 hairpin also offer some opportunity. Strategy and safety car timing are often decisive here.

Madrid Street Circuit

Madrid, Spain | 5.473 km (estimated) | 20 (estimated) turns | Lap record: N/A (inaugural race in 2026)

Street Circuit

The newest addition to the F1 calendar for 2026. Madrid's purpose-built circuit runs through the IFEMA exhibition complex area near the airport. As a brand-new venue, details are still emerging, but it promises a modern street circuit designed with F1's current standards for overtaking and spectator access. With Barcelona also remaining on the calendar, Spain now boasts two Grands Prix, reflecting the country's deep F1 heritage.

Famous sections: Details of corner names and character will emerge during the inaugural event. The circuit is designed to provide a mix of high-speed straights and technical sections.

Overtaking: As a purpose-designed modern venue, the Madrid circuit is expected to include good overtaking opportunities with long straights and heavy braking zones. Active aero zones should be prominent.

What to Watch For at Each Race

Not all circuits are the same. Here's how to think about what makes each race different:



Street circuits (Monaco, Singapore, Jeddah, Madrid): Walls punish mistakes, qualifying position matters more, safety cars are common

- Power circuits (Monza, Jeddah, Spa): Top speed and low drag are key, active aero (X-mode) has maximum impact, slipstreaming is a tactic
- High-downforce circuits (Monaco, Singapore, Budapest): Cornering speed matters most, overtaking is harder, strategy is crucial
- Mixed circuits (Silverstone, COTA, Suzuka): Reward all-round car balance, good for close racing across the entire field
- Weather-sensitive venues (Spa, Silverstone, Suzuka, Singapore): Rain can appear quickly, creating dramatic strategy decisions

Elevation and Altitude

Some circuits have significant elevation changes (Spa, COTA) that test suspension and aero. High-altitude venues like Mexico City (2,240m) reduce engine power and aero effectiveness due to thinner air, making them unique engineering challenges.